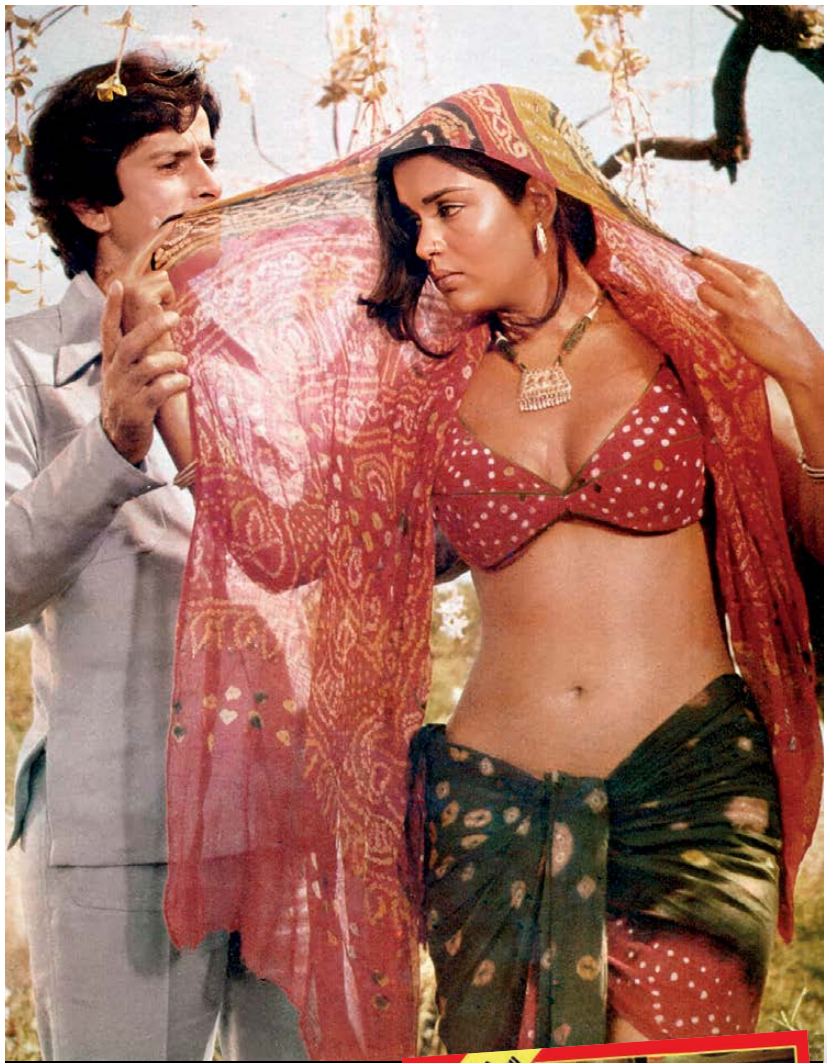
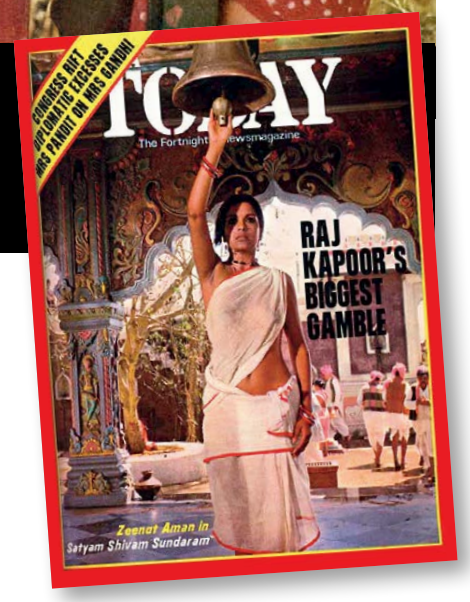


ENTERTAINMENT

BESIDES THE RAGE
Shashi Kapoor and Zeenat Aman in *Satyam Shivam Sundaram* (1978)



Mehra's *Zanjeer* (1973). Bachchan, a relative newcomer, was cast in the lead after major actors turned down the role. The movie was a massive hit and a turning point for Bachchan. A string of films in the same vein followed, all starring Bachchan, with his character often named 'Vijay': *Deewar* and *Sholay* in 1975, *Trishul* and *Don* in 1978, *Kala Patthar* (1979), *Shakti* (1982).... The audience found them cathartic, with memorable dialogues by the Salim-Javed duo, like "*Main aaj bhi phenke hue paise nahin uthata*" and, of course, "*Mere paas maa hai*". They were the ones responsible for eschewing the idealised romantic hero for an urban working-class character. Anger was no longer emotional—it was political. Once the duo split, the anger abated as well. ■

VIR SANGHVI, *Author, veteran journalist*

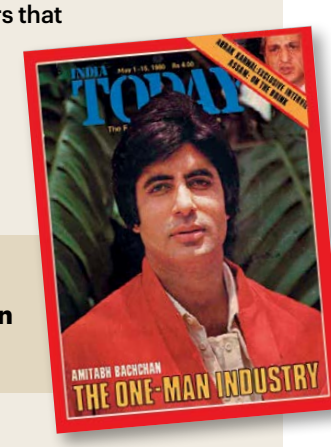
"He was one of the most fascinating people I interviewed"



Not all the stories I did for INDIA TODAY were political. Aroon and I had been talking about doing another movie cover story. I suggested Amitabh Bachchan. He was the number one star in India. Moreover, he had stopped talking to the press. So, if we got access to Bachchan, it would be a real scoop.

He met me on the set wearing a curious costume that included short trousers that billowed out and were then tied together at his knee with ribbons and a ruffled shirt. After I had explained the story to him, he said he would do it. Then, I threw in the difficult part. I wanted access to his home, to his family (parents, wife, brother, etc.) and to him, all day, for at least a week. To my surprise, he agreed.

Amitabh Bachchan: The One-Man Industry
May 15, 1980



And so I spent something like a week shadowing him. He turned out to be one of the most fascinating people I had ever interviewed. All the clichés about him were true: he came early to the sets, was disciplined, a vegetarian who did not drink, and was devoted to his family. But there were things that were less obvious. He had a strong sense of propriety. And, most important, he could laugh at himself.

The story appeared on the cover of INDIA TODAY, creating a storm, and Bachchan shut down again for the next several years, refusing all interviews.